

My 5G life

WE HEAR IT ALL THE TIME. 5G IS COMING,

5G will change everything. 5G will allow robot surgery. 5G will solve all of humanity's problems! It's the latest buzzword now, so of course everyone who can add it to their list of jargon does, just as AI was last year, and continues to be this year as well. And it's not like we're complaining. The promise of faster broadband speeds with lower latency is like a dream for all of us geeks. For me, living here in Australia, 5G was my only hope of decent net speeds. Let me elaborate.

In 2007, the incoming Australian government promised that they would build a National Broadband Network (NBN) that would increase the rather pathetic speeds most Australians were used to. Since ADSL was the norm across the country at the time, speeds were slow – not as bad as the connection I had in India in 2007, but slow by the standards of most first world countries. In 2009, the government promised that 93% of the population would have fibre to the premises (FTTP) by 2020 at the cost of about 40 billion AUD to the taxpayer.

Needless to say, because it was 2009, and because it was an infrastructure project of mammoth proportions, the installations went rather slowly. There were negotiations with private players holding it up, because NBN had to buy out their infrastructure to use wire pits and pipes the private companies had installed (at their own costs) in streets around Australia. Obviously, the opposition jumped at the opportunity to criticise the NBN, and came up with a plan that they claimed would speed up deployment and also save the taxpayer billions of dollars! In 2013, what was called the Multi-Technology Mix (MTM), was promised to the public by the opposition, and it basically promised fibre to the node (FTTN) connections, which meant optical fibre and existing copper would be used together to connect you to the internet, instead of drawing expensive fibre all the way to your house, and then installing a box inside your house, etc. When they won the election, this is exactly what they converted the NBN into, and thus, we come back to my predicament.

In January, I bought a house, and despite my pleas to my wife to only consider those houses that had FTTP connections, she was more interested in the actual house, land size, proximity to schools and shops, and other such unimportant details. Personally I'd be happy living

in a shack so long as it had a fast net connection and a place for my multiple monitor desktop setup... As luck would have it, I ended up with a house that was on an FTTN connection and almost a km away from the closest node, which meant a km of copper wire between me and fibre optics. All the houses I rented up to this point were either FTTP or FTTN with the node less than 100m away from the house. The result? I went from net speeds of 100/40 Mbps (up/down), to 50/19 Mbps. Heck, all of the guys in Digit have better connections at home than I did here, in a supposedly first world country.

Needless to say, I was always complaining about this, and driving my wife up the wall. And then a ray of hope emerged...

My home is actually less than 100m away from a large service provider's satellite dish setup, and this means that a large compound with a lot of ISP equipment is (literally) a stone's throw away. In February, they announced that they wanted to run a 5G trial, which was open to residents of a select few suburbs around Australia. My suburb was one of those and I jumped to sign up. Then silence ensued for a few months. In the beginning of July I got a call, and in a few days received a Nokia Fastmile 5G Gateway, spent two days fiddling about with it and carrying it all over the house to find the ideal spot. Heck, I even went on to the road (with a very long power extension cable), to try and find signal strengths in open air. That got me a few stares from the neighbours!

Now I'm sitting here with a fixed wireless, 5G connection that I pay about Rs 3,500 a month for (I was paying Rs 4,500 a month for the earlier 50/19 FTTN connection), and get speeds of between 250 Mbps and 400 Mbps down and 40 to 60 Mbps up. And this isn't even proper 5G on the millimeter wave (mmwave), it's still just sub-8 GHz. I immediately disconnected the more expensive FTTN NBN as it was worthless to me, and this is something that's going to happen all over Australia in FTTN houses once 5G really rolls out...

This is something India is going through currently, as many players in large cities are trying to connect you via fibre. But are they too late already? With 5G coming, and making much more sense in crowded cities in India, is the idea of fibre or copper to your home just dead on arrival? Indian companies better learn from the Australian government's mistakes... 



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